public, or were they mere decorative motifs and conventions detached from real life (akin to how we Indians expect our movie stars on screen to break out in choreographed song and dance, while never doing so in our own lives)?

The few texts that survive from the Chandela realm shed little light on their artistic motivations. All we have are clues from a few Sanskrit inscriptions, a philosophical court play titled *Prabodhachandrodaya* (more on this later) and other data from elsewhere in India. Over the decades, many theories have tried to explain the purpose and meaning of the explicit erotica on temple walls, such as: (1) the sculptures show what the townsfolk were doing when the celestial wedding pageant rolled by their city, and the erotica represents the consummation of the divine marriage;[8] (2) the erotic sculptures were designed to impart sex education to the Chandela public; (3) they celebrate the male– female creative union; (4) they are a visual rendition of the *Kamasutra*; (5) they were driven by the sexually liberal and reformist agenda of a royal family; (6) they show the rampant hedonism or cultural decadence of the Chandela society; and so on.

But these theories don't survive the most basic questions one might ask. What explains the wide range of sexual acts on the panels? Why did the sculptors express the idea of male–female creative union in such explicit, rather than figurative, ways? What about the panels on homosexuality that have nothing to do with fertility or male–female union? Desai has also persuasively argued that Khajuraho's erotica should not be seen as 'illustrated *Kamasutra*', as it is often sold to gullible tourists.[9] The *Kamasutra* is a secular treatise on the 'techniques' of love and courtship (more on this soon), 'whereas the erotic figures of Khajuraho, as also of Bhubaneshwar, Konarak and other Indian temples, belong to a different tradition, where both religious (Tantric) and worldly interest could merge'.[10] It is also not easy to reconcile the theory of rampant hedonism and cultural decadence with what we know of the feudal order and religious orientation of the royals and the temple-going public in the Chandela realm. After all, even if this was the work of mere voluptuaries, why didn't they restrict all erotic depictions to their private living spaces and pleasure palaces? Why did they feel the need to so prominently stamp their temples with erotica? And why did these depictions vanish a few centuries later?